

5.d) Pattern of Culture and Special Genius

The concept of pattern of culture has been given by Ruth Benedict, a culture personality school scholar in her book "Patterns of Culture".

She postulates that culture is a magnified form of personalities i.e. there are certain common personalities among a group of people who effect their culture.

i.e. Personality affects culture.

Culture traits (smallest units) when arrayed around a nuclear complex ~~form~~ focus form culture complex which when integrated is a bigger complex form culture pattern.

This integration in culture is caused by a 'common tendency' which she names as special genius.

Among her fieldwork among Pueblo Zuni, Dobu & Kwakiutl she gives 2 special genius.

- ① Apollonian : Peace loving, cooperative
Ex: Pueblo Zuni
- ② Dionysian : Competitive, materialistic aggressive
Ex: Kwakwaka'wakw, Dobuans

These differences in personality eventually shape their culture behaviour wherein Zuni use magic for aesthetic purposes & Dobuans use it to harm others. Kwakwaka'wakw metemorphosis seen in potlatch while Zuni have simpler ways.

Criticism:

- 1) Morris Opler: 'Apache way of life': There can be many genuine cultures confined to only two.
- 2) Ignored conflicts among Zuni & cooperation among Kwakwaka'wakw to prove her theory.

This culture pattern study has been expanded to national character studies & are now even more relevant when used in business anthropology.